

Lewis & Clark National Heritage Trail Project Idea:

A Bird Sanctuary on Brunot's Island

Brunot's Island just west of downtown Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania on the Ohio River, was the site of Meriwether Lewis' first stop with the keel boat that was launched on August 31, 1803 in that city and the site of a dramatic incident with his most advanced weapon, a pneumatic repeating air rifle. Today, the island is home to a small power generating facility and is owned by GenOn Corporation who is willing to explore ideas to preserve both nature and history on the part of the island that faces the city.

Islands are natural resting, nesting, and feeding places for birds, and the mostly tree covered eastern half of the island could serve as a vital stop during the seasonal migrations of various avian species as well. So, in cooperation with the National Aviary, the Lewis and Clark Trail Heritage Foundation, the National Park Service, the Heinz History Center, Friends of the Riverfront, the City of Pittsburgh, the Pennsylvania Bureau of Historic Preservation and others, GenOn Corporation may seek to create a habitat zone that will limit human contact and maintain their ownership while enhancing the qualities of the natural world, promote historic education and encourage outdoor recreation in the Pittsburgh area. This part of the island could see such additions as osprey towers, bat boxes, wildflower groves, humming bird feeders, ponds and an observation platform for birders, all the while observing the security concerns of the existing power plant.

The public can observe the island remotely and learn its history from an interpretive pavilion on the nearby recreation trail along the North Shore of the Ohio River, from the river itself, and from a possible scenic pull out on State Route 51 which lies along the river's southern bank.

This project would allow **Brunot's Island** to take its place among the other outstanding Lewis and Clark sites across the country while preserving the interests and workings of industry. GenOn Corporation recognizes the need for education into our region's early history while providing our ongoing energy needs and seeks to enhance the attractiveness and quality of life in the Pittsburgh region by implementing this project.

*For more information about this project, please contact John McNulty at (412) 992-1424
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Why Is Brunot's Island Important?

Conventional wisdom has it that the journals of the Lewis and Clark Expedition began when the Corps of Discovery started making it's way up the Missouri River in the Spring of 1804. However, Captain Lewis actually started journaling briefly at the beginning of the staging phase of the expedition coming down the Ohio River in the late summer of 1803.

On August 31st, 1803 Lewis writes, *"Left port of Pittsburgh at 11:00 o'clock with 11 hands, 7 of which are soldiers, a pilot and three young men on trial, they having proposed to go with me throughout the voyage. Arrived at Bruno's Island three miles below, halted a few minutes. Went on shore and being invited by some of the gentlemen present to try my air gun which I had purchased brought it on shore, charged it, and fired myself seven times 55 yards with pretty good success. After which a Mr. Blaze Cenas, being unacquainted with the management of the gun, suffered her to discharge herself accidentally. The ball passed through the hat of a woman about 40 yards distant, cutting her temple about the fourth of the diameter of the ball. She fell instantly and the blood gushing from her temple, we were all in the greatest consternation and supposed she was dead. But in a minute she revived, to our inexpressible satisfaction, and by examination we found the wound by no means mortal or even dangerous."*

This entry marks the beginning of a classic piece of American literature and **Brunot's Island** was not only the first landing of the keel boat that was built in Pittsburgh, but also the first time when something of note happened. The air gun incident on **Brunot's Island** is the only time in which an American civilian was wounded as a result of the West's most famous expedition and the last time Lewis ever let a civilian handle his most advanced weapon. Think what a bad omen it would have been if Lewis had to report to President Jefferson that a civilian female had died as a result of his unwise decision to pass the air gun around on the very first day of taking troops under his command in the field. Instead, he had a close call and learned from his mistake as any good leader would.

Brunot's Island deserves to take its place among the other significant, well known sites along the Lewis and Clark Trail and have its story in the Pittsburgh area be told for the public today and for future generations!

**Activities for Brunot's Island Bird Sanctuary and North Shore
Interpretive Center :**

Bird watching	Biking	Hiking
Kayaking and canoeing	Eco-education	
Picnicking	Botanical preservation and study	
Historic Education	Air rifle demonstrations	

Types of visitors that would come to this location:

Lewis and Clark enthusiasts	Bird Watchers
Kayakers and Paddlers	Botany & History students
Recreational power boaters	Gun enthusiasts
School groups	Living Historians

Benefits that can be derived from this park:

A bird sanctuary with historic significance such as *Brunot's Island* would make Pittsburgh a more attractive place to live.

Pittsburgh's image as a green city & civic pride will be enhanced.

Sustainable development in the nearby area could be sparked.

Outdoor health, recreation and education opportunities will increase.

Endangered plants and Lewis' discoveries can be shown and protected.

People will be inspired watching rare bird species soar over the rivers.

A cleaner *Brunot's Island* will help make the Ohio River cleaner.

Public Interaction with Brunot's Island via:

A - 'Gen On Pavilion' - along North Shore recreation trail, upper level allows viewing of birds, lower level tells story of Lewis & Clark, concession stands

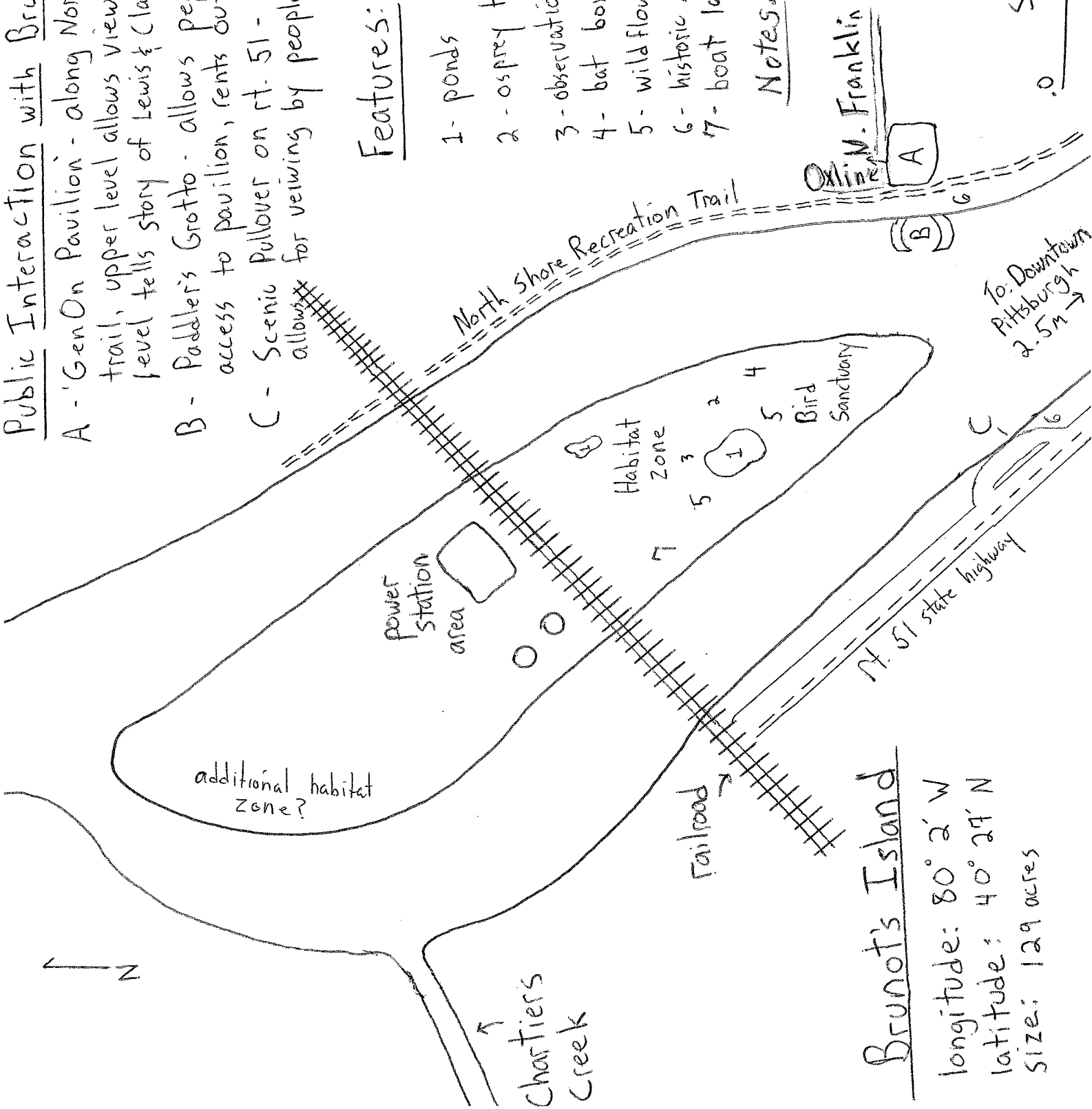
B - Paddler's Grotto - allows people on the river access to pavilion, rents out kayaks & canoes

C - Scenic PULLOVER on rt. 51 - tells the story & allows for viewing by people in motorized vehicles

Features:

- 1- ponds
- 2 - osprey tower
- 3 - observation blind for birds
- 4 - bat boxes
- 5 - wild flower groves
- 6 - historic markers
- 7 - boat landing area

Notes:



Brunot's Island

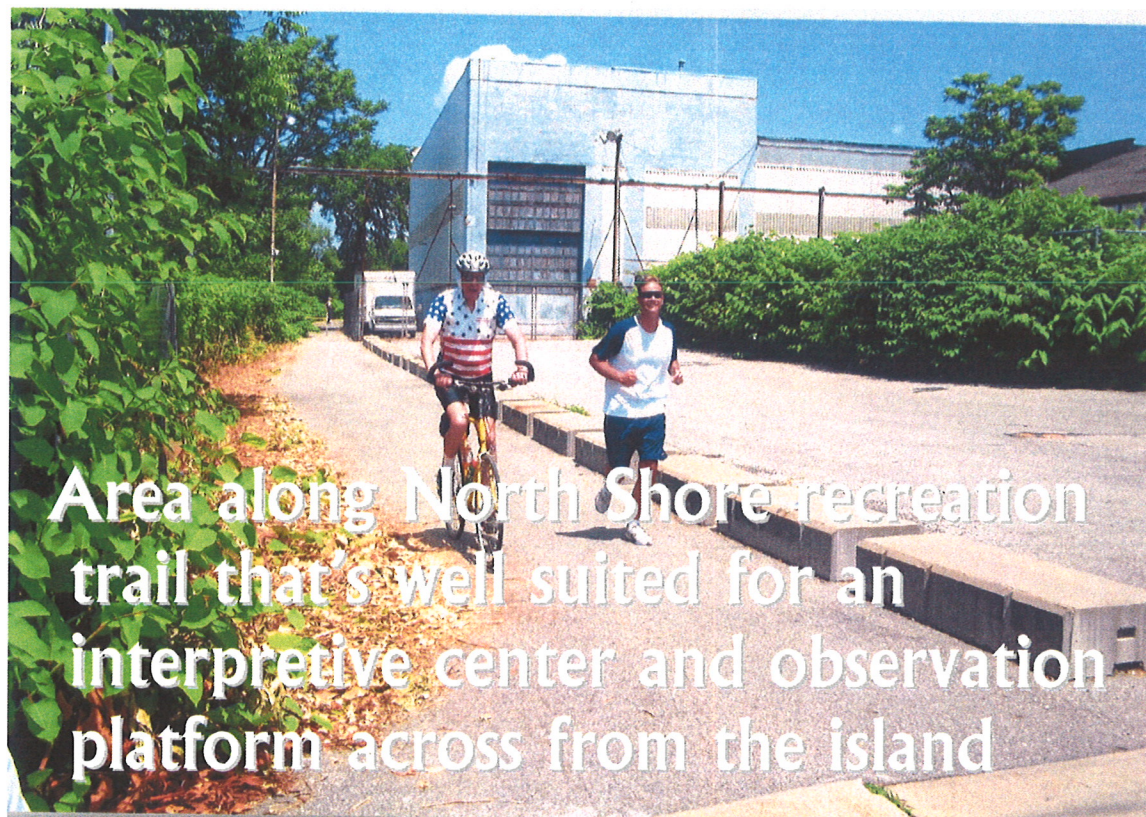
longitude: $80^{\circ} 2' W$

latitude: $40^{\circ} 27' N$

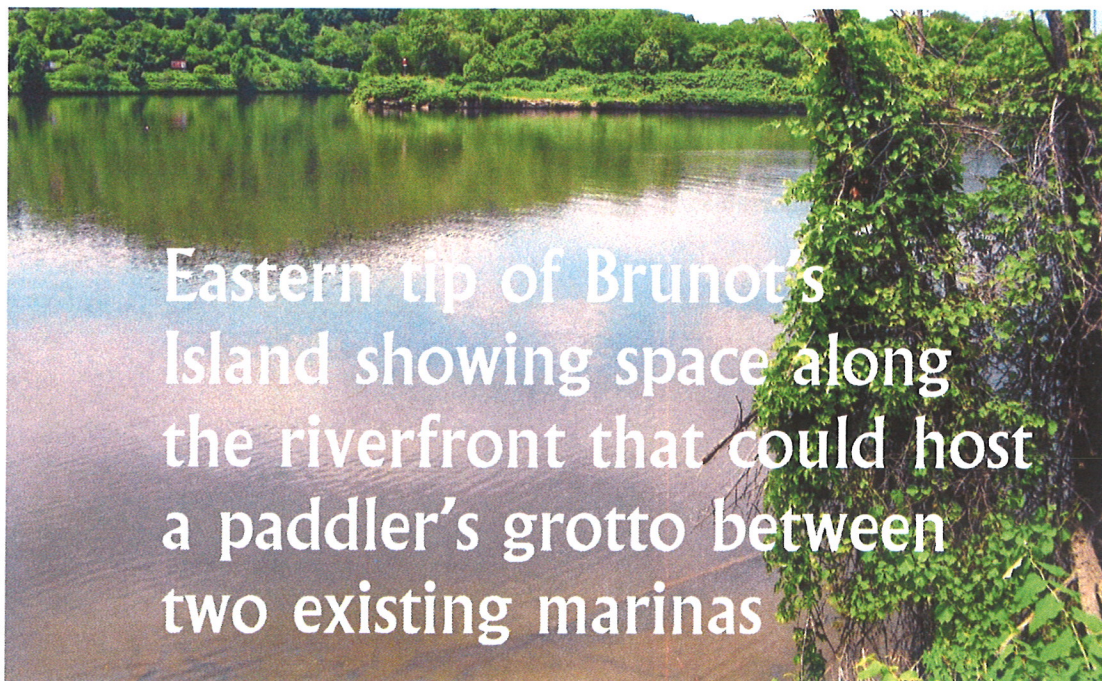
size: 129 acres

Schle:

5 miles



Area along North Shore recreation trail that's well suited for an interpretive center and observation platform across from the island



Eastern tip of Brunot's Island showing space along the riverfront that could host a paddler's grotto between two existing marinas